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Chatbot or cheatbot? Moral judgments of AI usage in academic writing

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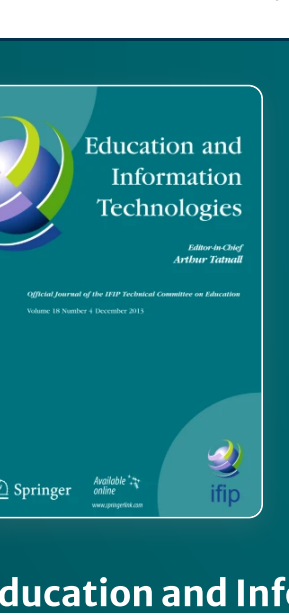

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Yi Xu, Junyi Guo, Dong Zhou & Mengxuan Li

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Abstract

As generative AI becomes increasingly integrated into academic writing, ethical ambiguities emerge, especially concerning AI-giarism—where AI-generated content blurs traditional understandings of plagiarism. In addressing these complexities, the present study examines moral judgments across three distinct scenarios of AI usage: (1) Direct copying AI-generated content, (2) AI-supported collaborative writing, and (3) Minimal AI-tool use (e.g., proofreading, grammar checking, and information searches). Grounded in dual-process models of moral reasoning and technological mediation theories, this study investigates how cognitive awareness of plagiarism standards and negative emotions toward plagiarism influence moral judgments and underlying psychological mechanisms. An analysis of data from 415 participants reveals significant variations in ethical evaluations according to context: direct copying is subject to strict moral condemnation, while collaborative writing elicits moderate judgments, and minimal AI-tool use remains ethically ambiguous. Perceived moral intensity mediates both the influences of cognitive awareness and negative emotional attitudes towards plagiarism, emphasizing the need for moral judgment theories to explicitly incorporate context-dependent perceptions of ethical severity. Furthermore, participants' experience of AI usage moderates the mediation pathways, highlighting the critical role of AI literacy in fostering sophisticated ethical judgments. These findings contribute to theoretical understandings of moral reasoning within AI-mediated academic writing contexts and suggest practical implications for educational institutions and publishers, recommending clear, context-sensitive ethical guidelines and targeted AI-literacy initiatives to effectively manage evolving human-AI collaborative practices.

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Data availability

The data used in this study were collected through a questionnaire developed by integrating and adapting items from established measurement scales. The original questionnaire was administered in Chinese, and English translations of representative items are provided in the manuscript. Due to privacy considerations, the full dataset is not publicly available but can be obtained from the corresponding author upon reasonable request.

Notes

1. *While consensus on defining "AI plagiarism" ("AI-giarism") remains unsettled, this study specifically defines direct AI plagiarism as submitting fully or nearly fully AI-generated content without significant human modification and without clearly disclosing AI involvement, thus violating academic integrity standards.*

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Author information

Authors and Affiliations

USC-SJTU Institute of Cultural and Creative Industry, Shanghai Jiao Tong University, Tanjiatang Road No.155, Shanghai, 200241, China
Yi Xu, Dong Zhou & Mengxuan Li

Hugh Downs School of Human Communication, Arizona State University, Arizona, 85281, USA
Junyi Guo

Contributions

Yi Xu was responsible for the topic selection, research design, and led the manuscript writing.

Junyi Guo conducted data organization and analysis, created all figures and tables, and contributed to the manuscript writing.

Dong Zhou participated in manuscript structuring, reviewing, and partial writing.

Mengxuan Li organized the experiment and was in charge of questionnaire distribution and data collection.

Corresponding author

Correspondence to Yi Xu.

Ethics declarations

Ethical approval

This study was approved by the Institutional Review Board (IRB) of [Institution name anonymized for review].

Consent to participate

Informed consent was obtained electronically from all individual participants included in the study.

Consent to publish

The study does not include any identifiable participant data. All participants were informed that their responses would be used for academic research and publication purposes and provided their consent accordingly.

Competing interests

The authors have no relevant financial or non-financial interests to disclose.

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